A. General Information

Information Requested	Information provided by the PI
1. **Heritage Craft Name**	*Baluchari and Swarnachari Sarees*
2. **Affiliated Institute**	*Indian Institute of Technology, Delhi*
3. **Principal Investigators**	*Prof. Wazed Ali (PI) and Prof. Apurba Das (Co-PI)*
4. **Official Project Title**	*Empowering Bengal's Heritage through Quality Innovation and Livelihood Upliftment in Baluchari and Swarnachari Sarees*

1. Introduction

- Brief description of the textile product
  - Length- 5 m-6.5 m
  - Width- 116 cms-122 cms
  - Weight- Depends upon quantity of mulberry/tassar silk yarn used along with the amount of zari work is done (>400gm)
  - Three parts- Body of the saree, Border, and Pallu/Anchal
  - Border of the saree- Bright and/or dark vibrant colour
  - Appearance- Shiny
  - Pallu and Border- Have rich zari work when compared to the body
  - Two high capacity Jacquard simultaneously– one for ground
- Geographical area of production (map if possible)
  - Bisnupur, West Bengal
- Key characteristics (material, technique, motifs, end-use)
  - Material- Mulberry silk from Bengal and Bangalore
  - Technique- Jacquard loom
  - Motifs- Kalka, Persian motifs, European lifestyle, Mythological events, Indian ritual, Social impact scenes
  - End use- Saree
- **Why is it classified as a *textile heritage***
  - Unique motifs and patterns that historically depict the mythological events, geo-political issues and also socio-politico-cultural events, Found only in Bengal region (Bishnupur), Also received GI tag
- Cultural and traditional significance
  - Socio-politico-cultural historical events, depiction of Indian rituals, events of mythological stories, Persian art form
- Current market presence (local/national/export)
  - Export

2. History

- Origin of the craft (region/community)
  - Earlier, Baluchar (Murshidabad) and currently in Bishnupur, West Bengal
- Historical development
  - In the year 1704, Mursid Quli Khan, the first independent nawab of Bengal, moved the capital of Bengal presidency from Dacca to Baluchar (modern day Jiaganj in Murshidabad) and craftsmen shifted from Dacca and Benaras to Baluchar. After the massive flood, skilled craftsmen shifted to Bisnupur, and the Malla dynasty promoted this skill. During the British era, a decline in this skill was observed due to increased costs and the introduction of automated textile machinery. In 1956, the Silk Khadi Seva Mandal and Akshay Kumar Das revived this skill in Bishnupur.
- Major transformations over time (materials, techniques, designs)
  - Natural dye to synthetic dye
  - Handloom to powered jacquard loom
  - Currently, design motifs are the mythological stories described in narrative way. However, during Mughal and British era, these baluchari sares depicts the socio-politico-cultural events
- Timeline (mandatory): Ancient → Colonial → Post-independence → Present
- Influence of government policies, industrialization, or globalization

3. Manpower

- Number of families/artisans currently involved
  - ~12,000–15,000 individuals directly involved in Baluchari weaving and allied work
- Comparison with past (10–20 years ago)
  - Shift from independent weavers to wage labor under master weavers/traders
- Gender-wise and age-wise participation
  - Male: 60–70% (loom operation, design execution)
  - Female: 30–40% (pre-loom, reeling, dyeing, ancillary work)

  Age distribution

  - Above 40 years: Majority skilled weavers
  - 20–40 years: Moderate participation
  - Below 25 years: Declining interest (critical issue)
- Skill levels (master artisans, helpers, trainees)
  - Master weavers:
    Design development, jacquard programming, motif creation
    ~10–15%
  - Skilled weavers:
    Operate looms, produce sarees
    ~50–60%
  - Helpers / ancillary workers:
    Silk preparation, dyeing, finishing

~20–30%

- Average income per household (range)
  - The wage for one saree is Rs.1,800, which is divided between two artisans. Each artisan gets Rs. 300.
- Livelihood dependency (% income from this craft)
  - Primary occupation (weaving): ~70–80% households
  - Partial/secondary occupation: ~20–30%
  - Increasing diversification into:
  - Agriculture, Daily wage labour and Small business or grocery shop
- Reasons for increase/decrease in workforce
  - Low wages despite high product value
  - Decline of cooperative societies
  - Competition from:
  - Power looms
  - Machine-made imitations
  - Lack of direct market access
  - Long production time (7–10 days per saree)
- Migration trends (if any)
  - Moving to cities (Kolkata, Delhi, etc.) for better opportunities
  - Switching to construction, service jobs
- Key challenges faced by artisans
  - Health issues in lower abdomen, and eyes
  - Very low wage vs market price (₹5,000–₹30,000 saree vs ₹300 wage)
  - Dependence on middlemen
- Expectations/aspirations of the community
  - Fair wages and profit-sharing models
  - Direct access to: Designers, Export markets and Revival of cooperative societies
  - Government support in: Marketing, Branding and Digital platforms

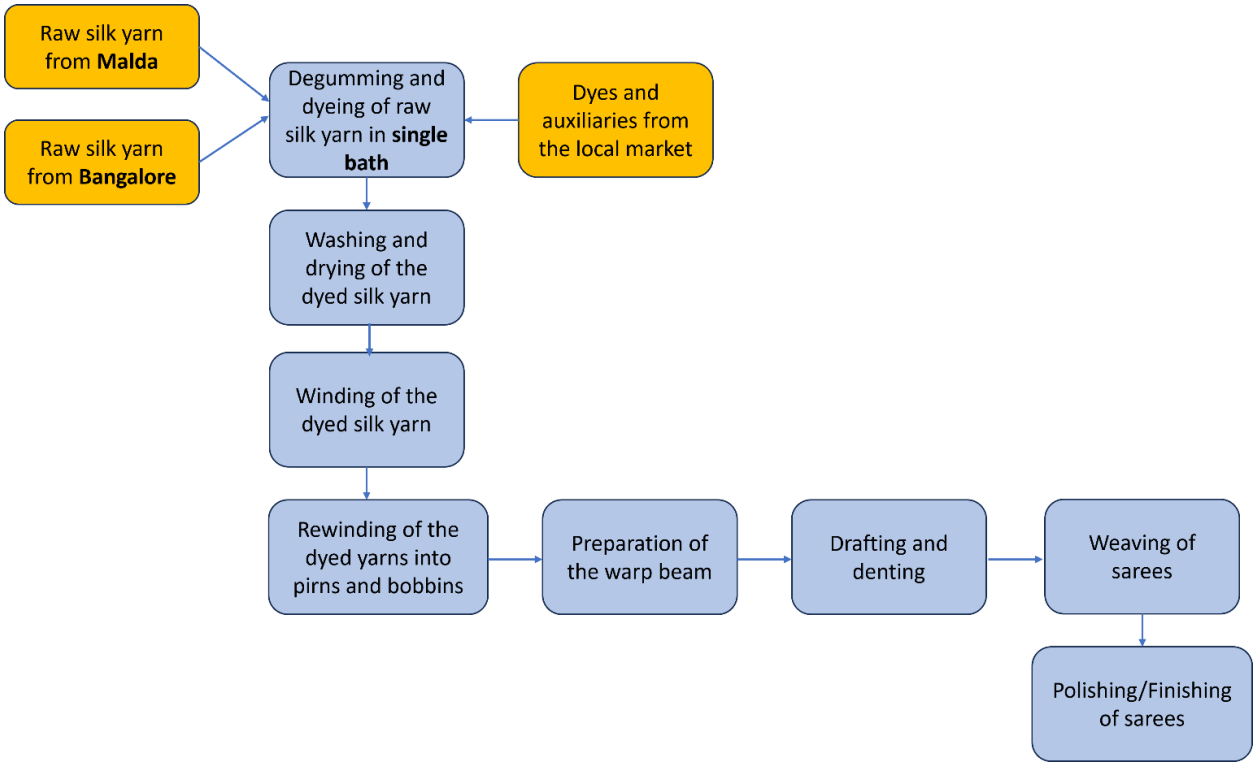
4. GI tag

- Why GI tag given
  - Because it is a heritage product
- Unique features
  - In according to GI Tag document, the uniqueness of the design which make it different from other brocade sarees are
    - All motifs are surrounded by a rectangular or square geometric structure
    - The rectangular or square forms are not simple line structures; these are represented by floral or other motifs in a rectangular or square form
    - Most of the motifs are presented in side-facing
    - Pallu consists of a main motif inside a large rectangular structure which is surrounded by other motifs inside small rectangular structure
    - The border motif is a small motif present in “Anchal”

- Specify the GI Tag document no.
  - 173 (Registration Date: 06.01.2012)

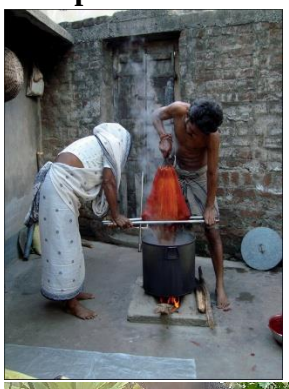
5. Manufacturing steps

- Detailed manufacturing process with a flowchart and images.



- How much raw materials are used per saree
  One saree weigh around 500 g for baluchari saree.
  - Warp yarn- 160g
  - Weft yarn- 400g
  - Selvedge yarn- 100g
- Where the raw materials are sourced
  - Mulberry yarn from Malda (weft) and Bangalore (warp)
  - Dyes and auxiliaries from local market
  - Wax
- How much energy is utilized in each process
- Form of energy- wood/coal/solar
  - LPG used for Dyeing

6. **Real photos of Cluster /Product/manufacturing process (Geo tagged if possible)**



Cluster visited – Bishnupur Tanthin Tant Shramik Samabay Samity Ltd (Bishnupur, West Bengal)
House of Weaver – Shri Swapan Mandal
Master dyer – Shri Joydeb Das

7. **Videos (Short clips of weavers describing their journey)**
   Not Available
8. **Technological Intervention**

New technologies in yarn treatment, weaving, printing, eco-friendly dyes, water conservation in the process, sustainable practices etc.